

Hospital-Acquired Pressure Injury Prevention and Staging

Policy Number	POL-NUR-009	Owner / Department	Nursing / Wound, Ostomy & Continence (WOCN)
Effective Date	2023-08-01	Version	3.3
Last Revised	2026-03-10	Next Review	2028-03-10
Approved By	Patient Safety & Quality Committee	Applies To	All inpatient and observation units

1. Purpose

To prevent hospital-acquired pressure injuries (HAPIs) through risk assessment and skin care, and to stage injuries consistently using the NPIAP staging system.

2. Policy — Assessment and Prevention

- Complete a head-to-toe skin assessment and a Braden Scale risk assessment on admission, every shift, and on change in condition.
- Implement a prevention bundle for at-risk patients: repositioning schedule, pressure-redistribution surface, moisture management, and nutrition review.
- A pressure injury present on admission is documented as such; one that develops after admission is hospital-acquired.

3. NPIAP Staging

Stage	Description
Stage 1	Intact skin with localized non-blanchable erythema.
Stage 2	Partial-thickness skin loss with exposed dermis; may present as an intact or ruptured serum-filled blister.
Stage 3	Full-thickness skin loss; adipose (fat) visible; no exposed fascia, muscle, tendon, or bone.
Stage 4	Full-thickness skin and tissue loss with exposed or palpable fascia, muscle, tendon, ligament, cartilage, or bone.
Unstageable	Full-thickness loss obscured by slough or eschar so depth cannot be confirmed.
Deep Tissue Pressure Injury	Persistent non-blanchable deep red, maroon, or purple discoloration, or a blood-filled blister.

4. Severity & Reporting

IMPORTANT — A hospital-acquired Stage 3, Stage 4, or unstageable pressure injury is a Serious Reportable Event and is classified SEV-1. Stage 2 HAPIs are SEV-2. Notify the attending provider and the WOCN nurse, and file an event report per POL-RM-013.

5. References

- NPIAP, Pressure Injury Staging System (2016 revision).
- National Quality Forum, Serious Reportable Events — Stage 3/4 and unstageable HAPI.
- Related: POL-RM-013 (severity & reporting).